

Saint Thomas Becket, Bishop and Martyr

Feast Day: December 29:

Patron Saint of:

England, Church of England.

Protector of diocesan clergy (priests and deacons who serve pastorally in parishes). and church workers, advocating for their rights.

Saint of martyrs, symbolizing sacrifice for faith and justice.

Guardian of the oppressed, especially those facing injustice.

Patron of universities and students, reflecting his scholarly background.

Associated with the city of Canterbury, where he was martyred.

Canonized by Pope Alexander III on February 21, 1173

Liturgical color: White (Red only where celebrated as a Feast)

Archbishop Becket was immediately praised as a martyr, and veneration of him quickly spread across England. Three years after Thomas Becket's death, Pope Alexander III declared him a saint. Four years after Thomas Becket's death, King Henry visited the saint's tomb and did public penance for the role he played in his death. Saint Thomas Becket's tomb became a popular place of pilgrimage in Europe, and numerous miracles were attributed to his intercession.

As we honor this heroic archbishop and saint of God, ponder the firm resolve that Saint Thomas had in defense of the faith. Guided by divine inspiration, he knew in his heart the necessity to resist the king's unjust intrusion into the Church's governance and administration. Many of the faithful honor Saint Thomas by invoking his intercession, praying fervently for the universal right to worship God freely, and for the liberty of the faithful clergy to spread the Gospel and administer the Sacraments unhindered.

Prayer:

Saint Thomas Becket, you lived much of your life in a worldly pompous way, but upon being consecrated a bishop, you turned to a life of prayer, penance, and defense of the Church. Please pray for me, that I will also turn from all worldly attractions and will devote myself wholeheartedly to the service of God and His Church. Saint Thomas Becket, pray for me. Jesus, I trust in You.

In the Catholic Church, sainthood is the final stage of a formal canonization process: Servant of God, then Venerable, then Blessed, then Saint.

Main steps

1. A local cause is opened after death.

The person must be deceased, and the local bishop usually begins the investigation, often after a waiting period unless the pope waives it.

2. The person is named Servant of God.

This means the Church has officially begun examining the person's life and writings.

3. The Church investigates heroic virtue or martyrdom.

The bishop and then the Vatican review testimony, documents, and the person's reputation for holiness to determine whether they lived a life of heroic virtue or died as a martyr.

4. The person is declared Venerable.

If the pope approves the findings of heroic virtue, the person is given the title "Venerable".

5. Beatification makes the person Blessed.

Normally, one verified miracle through the person's intercession is required after death; martyrs can be beatified without that miracle requirement.

6. Canonization declares the person a Saint.

Usually, a second verified miracle is required after beatification; then the pope formally canonizes the person as a saint.

What it means

Canonization does not mean the Church "makes" someone holy; it means the Church publicly declares that the person is in heaven and worthy of universal veneration. The process is careful because it involves historical evidence, theological review, and medical examination of alleged miracles.

[wedaretosay](<https://wedaretosay.com/what-steps-are-in-the-beatification-and-canonization-process/>)

Here's a simple flowchart version of the Catholic canonization process:

After death

→ Local bishop begins an investigation into the person's life, writings, and reputation for holiness.

[franciscanmedia]

Servant of God

→ The cause is officially opened.

Venerable

→ The Vatican confirms the person lived a life of heroic virtue, or died as a martyr.

Blessed

→ Usually requires one verified miracle after death; martyrs can be beatified without a miracle.

Saint

→ Usually requires a second verified miracle after beatification, and then the pope formally canonizes the person.

A very short version is: Investigate → Venerable → Blessed → Saint.

Banners with the official images of (L to R) Sister Irmã Dulce Pontes, Mother Giuseppina Vannini, John Henry Newman, Mother Mariam Thresia and Marguerite Bays hang on the facade of St. Peter's Basilica Oct. 10, 2019, three days before their canonization.

Banners with the official images of (L to R) Sister Irmã Dulce Pontes, Mother Giuseppina Vannini, John Henry Newman, Mother Mariam Thresia and Marguerite Bays hang on the facade of St. Peter's Basilica Oct. 10, 2019, three days before their canonization. (photo: Daniel Ibáñez / CNA/EWTN News)

Joseph Pronechen

Blogs

May 28, 2021

Short or long, the steps to sainthood follow a definite route, with all roads to it leading to and from Rome.

These steps on the way to declaring a person a saint have no set time limit. Well on his way is Carlo Acutis, who died at age 15 in 2006 and was declared “Blessed” in October 2020. Then there is Blessed Margaret of Castello, who lived and died 700 years ago. Pope Francis approved her canonization this past April.

Let’s look at the steps leading to someone being declared a saint, dictating for certain they are in heaven with the Lord.

Grassroots Devotion

The Vatican’s Congregation for the Causes of Saints points out that it begins with a person’s “fame for holiness.” Do the faithful speak of these men and women and their exemplary lives, positive influence, apostolic fruitfulness and edifying deaths?

To make sure their reputation for sanctity is enduring, the official process of looking into their cause for canonization can’t begin until five years after they die. Although it rarely happens, the pope can waive this requirement. Pope John Paul II waived three years from the waiting period for Mother Teresa of Calcutta. Benedict XVI waived all five years for John Paul II, whose cause started immediately.

The Diocesan Phase

Next comes the diocesan phase. A petitioner — usually a religious order or the bishop of the diocese where the man or woman died — can petition Rome to start the cause for canonization. With a nod of approval, he gets the ball rolling by appointing a postulator to collect documents and testimonies about the life and holiness of the possible saint-to-be who at this step is named a “Servant of God.” This step aims to confirm the person’s heroic virtues — with emphasis on “heroic,” meaning well above average.

The postulator will also seek further evidence of the person’s reputation for holiness — whether, in life and death, they had a reputation for sanctity and a life rich in virtues — or whether they were a martyr, confessor (a witness of the faith without being martyred) or made an offering of life (a new category added in 2017, which is defined “as the experience of a premature death due to the offering, or sacrificing, of one’s life out of Christian charity”).

The two ways used to reach this goal are, first, through the testimonies of people who knew the Servant of God and can give as many details about him or her as possible, and, second, through collecting and examining all the writings and documents concerning the Servant of God, including, of course, his or her own public and private

writings. In the case of John Paul II, that was voluminous. Sister Lucia of Fatima, whose cause is in progress, also has a long paper trail. This process looks to make sure there is not something contrary to faith or morality among this written content. It often takes years to complete, especially when the writings are extensive.

Off to Rome

When everything is collected and the bishop approves, the results are sent to Rome, to the Congregation for the Causes of Saints. What the diocese has gathered is placed into a formal volume called the *positio* — a work summarizing the evidence to demonstrate convincingly the life, heroic virtues and renown or reputation of the Servant of God. A theological commission studies and votes on it. It then moves to the cardinal and bishops of the congregation for their vote. Negative, and the cause stops with no appeal. Affirmative, it is sent to the Holy Father. If he agrees, the person gets the title of “Venerable.”

On to Beatification

The next step on the road to sainthood is beatification. If the candidate is a martyr for the faith, he or she is immediately made a “Blessed.” Others need a miracle recognized as happening through their posthumous intercession. This step is not easy. The miracle is commonly and normally a physical healing that medicine and science can’t explain. The miracle is presented to Rome, and the Congregation for the Causes of Saints has a group of specialists, believers and nonbelievers, who examine the miracle, which must be complete and lasting and have no natural explanation.

As far back as September 1743, Pope Benedict XIV created a guild of medical experts for this task. Over the years the regulations have been revised and updated by such popes as Venerable Pius XII, St. Paul VI and St. John Paul II. A majority of experts (5 out of 7, or 4 out of 6) must agree on the miracle.

Additionally, a theological commission judges whether or not the cure was a miracle and if this miracle is attributable to God through the Venerable’s intercession.

Then the bishops and cardinals of the congregation approve and send the results to the Holy Father, who authorizes the beatification. The saint-in-waiting is beatified and called “Blessed.” Their name is added to the liturgical calendar of their diocese or religious family.

Another Giant Step

At this point, the cause moves toward the final step of canonization and the title of “Saint.”

Necessary for this step is one additional miracle that happens after the beatification. The requirements are the same as for the first miracle, and the miracle must be attributed to the intercession of the Blessed. If everything passes the committees, the results are presented to the Holy Father, who then makes the final decision about declaring this particular man or woman to be a saint and worthy of public veneration by the whole Church.

Normally, the canonization takes place during Mass at the Vatican.

Particular Cases

The pope has the power to waive the requirements for one or both miracles. Recently, for the canonization of St. John XXIII, Pope Francis waived the requirement for a second miracle. And often that requirement for a second miracle is waived when it comes to martyrs. This April Pope Francis canonized Blessed Margaret of Castello, a blind 14th-century Italian lay Dominican who was beatified way back in 1609. He waived the need for a second miracle using this procedure, which is called “equivalent” canonization.

The new saint might have universal appeal and may be added to the general liturgical calendar as a memorial or optional memorial. If their appeal is more localized, they can be added to the calendar of a particular region, country or religious institute.

In any event, when the Church declares holy people to be saints, we are assured they are in heaven and we have a definite heavenly helper to ask for intercession.

All you holy men and women, pray for us!

How Does Someone Become a Saint?

René Ostberg

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Photo of Saint Carlos Acutis in a Catholic church.

How to Become a Saint: Canonization ExplainedStep one: Be Catholic.

See all videos for this article

In Roman Catholicism the process of declaring someone a saint is called canonization. According to the church’s law, the process cannot begin until five years after a person’s death, although this requirement can be waived by the pope. Mother Teresa, for example, died in 1997, but her cause for canonization was opened in 1999 after Pope John Paul II waived three years of the waiting period. Generally, there are three steps to canonization.

Examination

The first step involves examining a person's life for evidence of the individual's holiness. This investigation must be opened by the bishop of the deceased person's local diocese, although anyone or any group, such as a religious order, can petition the diocese on the person's behalf. If the cause for canonization is accepted and opened by the diocese, the person is recognized as a Servant of God. People who have received such recognition include Dorothy Day, Nicholas Black Elk, Thea Bowman, and Pedro Arrupe.

If the evidence for the person's cause is favorable, it is presented to the pope, who approves the Servant of God's candidacy for sainthood and declares the person Venerable. People who have been declared Venerable include Catherine McAuley, Augustus Tolton, Antoni Gaudí, Lucia dos Santos, and Matteo Ricci.

Beatification

Martyrs

Martyrs such as Ignacio Ellacuría and Dorothy Stang voluntarily suffered death rather than deny their religion. Because their sacrifice is considered sufficient proof of their holiness, martyrs are declared Blessed without the beatification process. However, martyrs require at least one miracle before they can be canonized.

The next step, beatification, involves verifying a miracle that has been attributed to the Venerable person's intercession. This verification process is similar to that of the examination in the first step. If the miracle is confirmed as authentic—for example, if there is no scientific basis for its occurrence, such as an inexplicable healing from a terminal illness—the pope grants the beatification and the Venerable person is declared Blessed. People who have been declared Blessed include Edmund Ignatius Rice, Michael J. McGivney, and Pope John Paul I.

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Canonization

The final step involves verifying a second miracle, after which a Blessed person can be declared a Saint. The saint is usually ascribed a feast day (typically the saint's date of death), which is added to the Catholic Church's general calendar and commemorated each year. People who were declared saints in the 21st century include Carlo Acutis, Óscar Romero, Pope John Paul II, Josephine Bakhita, and John Henry Newman. See also Britannica's List of Saints.

René Ostberg

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Agnes

Agnes Agnes with a lamb near her feet.

Roman Catholic Saints

“All you holy men and women pray for us.”

Melissa Petruzzello

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In Roman Catholicism and certain other Christian faith traditions, a saint is a holy person who is known for his or her “heroic sanctity” and who is thought to be in heaven. In the 10th century, Pope John XV formalized a process for the identification of saints. Before that time, saints were largely established by public cult. There are more than 10,000 saints recognized by the Roman Catholic Church, though the names and histories of some of these holy men and women have been lost to history.

The saints of the church are a diverse group of people with varied and interesting stories. Their ranks include martyrs, kings and queens, missionaries, widows, theologians, parents, nuns and priests, and “everyday people” who dedicated their lives to the loving pursuit of God. Religious and nonreligious people alike have found inspiration from their lives, particularly in the stories of saints who devoted themselves in service to the poor, sick, and disenfranchised, such as St. Mother Teresa and St. Vincent de Paul, among others. Many of the saints who were persecuted for their faith, such as St. Stephen and St. Perpetua, showed remarkable forgiveness and patiently suffered through their trials and tortures. Some are revered for their simplicity and humility, including St. Francis of Assisi and St. Thérèse of Lisieux. Several, notably St. Thomas Aquinas and St. Augustine, were writers and thinkers who shaped Western thought for centuries.

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Catholics venerate the saints and look to them as examples of lives well lived in the faith. Many find comfort in the knowledge that holy people shared in their same struggles, sins, doubts, or hardships and ask specific saints to pray for them. Some saints are the patrons of certain occupations or causes, and these saints are often invoked to aid people in those professions or situations. For example, St. Judas (Jude) is the patron saint of impossible or desperate causes, and many Catholics ask him to pray on their behalf for the resolution of seemingly impossible situations in their lives. Additionally, many Catholics take or are given a saint’s name for their confirmation. A confirmation saint is often seen as having an invested interest in fostering a new Catholic’s spiritual growth and is usually chosen because his or her life story resonates with the neophyte. Most saints have feast days observed by the Catholic Church in which their lives and contributions are formally celebrated, and some have large followings of devotees and even religious orders in their honor.

Melissa Petruzzello

Murder Most Horrid: The Grisliest Deaths of Roman Catholic Saints

Introduction

St. Stephen: Stoned to death

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St. Stephen

St. Stephen

Murder Most Horrid: The Grisliest Deaths of Roman Catholic Saints

Methods of martyrdom you may not have heard of.

Lorraine Murray

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Beheading, stoning, crucifixion, burning at the stake: In the annals of Roman Catholic saints, those methods of martyrdom are rather horrifically commonplace. There are hundreds of Catholic martyrs, put to death for their faith, but a few stories (some of which are likely only legends) stand out as particularly shocking.

St. Stephen: Stoned to death

Stoning is a traditional punishment, but among Christian martyrs, St. Stephen, who died in 36 ce in Jerusalem, was the first to suffer that fate. He was one of the first seven deacons chosen by the early Christian community and became an evangelist. His success in converting Jews drew the ire of the Sanhedrin (the supreme rabbinic court). His punishment for speaking against “this holy place and the law” was to be stoned to death. As is common to many icons of Catholic martyrdom, St. Stephen is often depicted in paintings as holding the method of his death: a basket of stones.

St. Sebastian: Surprisingly not by arrows

St. Sebastian

St. SebastianMartyrdom of Saint Sebastian by Michael van Coxie.

One might think from the fact that he is usually portrayed in art as having been shot through with arrows that St. Sebastian died (c. 288 in Rome) at the hands of a battery of archers, but no. That was just the first time he was “killed.” A Praetorian Guard under Diocletian (a committed persecutor of Christians), Sebastian was sentenced to death after it was found out that he was a Christian who had been converting his fellow soldiers. He was tied to a tree, his sentence of being killed with arrows was carried out, and he was left for dead. He wasn’t, however, and was found by a woman (later St. Irene) who nursed him back to health. Sebastian subsequently took the chance of appearing before Diocletian again; the emperor then had him clubbed to death, a punishment that did, in fact, work, and his body was dumped into a Roman sewer.

St. Lawrence: Grilled

St. Lawrence

St. Lawrence Statue of St. Lawrence in the church at Lampaul-Guimiliau, France. St. Lawrence is believed to have been martyred in 258 ce. He is shown holding the gridiron on which he is said to have been roasted to death by his torturers. He is also holding the Sacred Heart of Jesus.

Saint Lawrence was a victim of persecution by the Roman emperor Valerian in 258. A deacon under Pope (later St.) Sixtus II, he was disheartened when his patron was led off for his own execution. Sixtus “comforted” Lawrence by telling him that the same fate would befall him in three days. And he was right. Although Sixtus was beheaded, and Lawrence probably was as well, St. Lawrence’s legend states that he was grilled alive—as in, on an actual red-hot gridiron. It was recorded by his hagiographers that he bore his slow torture stoically, even quipping, in the style of a modern-day action-film hero, “Turn me over. I’m cooked on that side.”

St. Margaret Clitherow: Pressed to death

St. Margaret Clitherow

St. Margaret Clitherow English martyr St. Margaret Clitherow, 16th-century woodcut.

During the reign of Queen Elizabeth I, a devoted Protestant and Defender of the Faith in a military as well as a spiritual sense, Roman Catholics were forced to go underground. Margaret Clitherow, the Catholic-convert wife of a Protestant butcher in York, did all she could to protect her coreligionists. She allowed mass to be celebrated in her home secretly, and she also harbored priests there. Margaret fell afoul of a law instituted in 1583 that imposed the death penalty for such crimes, and her sentence was to be pressed to death. Pressed, on her back, over a sharp stone, with a door on top of her that was topped with an 800-pound weight. It took 15 minutes for her to die.

St. Cassian: Hacked to death by children

St. Cassian of Imola

St. Cassian of Imola

Cassian was a teacher in Imola, Italy, in 363. Formerly the bishop of Brescia, he became a schoolmaster after his banishment from that place. As a Christian teacher of pagan pupils during a period of Christian persecution in the Roman Empire, Cassian was in a dangerous position. By refusing to make sacrifice to the pagan gods, he angered the local officials, who sentenced him to death and turned him over to his students as his executioners. Why this should be the case and why they seemed happy to carry out the sentence is not entirely clear from historical accounts. But Cassian’s death was torturous because of it: The only instruments the students had at their disposal were small and non-lethal. The boys employed their tablets to bash Cassian and their styluses (pointed iron instruments for writing) and penknives to make a multitude of cuts and punctures all over his body for an

agonizingly extended time. Conscious through the long process, Cassian encouraged them to strike him forcefully, as he was eager to die for his faith.

St. Dymphna: Beheaded

It is not so much the manner of St. Dymphna's death—beheading—but the reason for it and the person behind it that is especially awful. Born in Ireland to a pagan king sometime before the middle of the 13th century (when her veneration was first recorded), Dymphna became a Christian convert. After the death of her mother, her deranged father demanded to marry her, a beautiful young woman who resembled his late wife. She refused and fled to Antwerp with her priest. The pair moved on to the town of Geel, where her father eventually found her. He reiterated his demand to marry her; she again refused. He had his servants kill the priest, but he himself cut off his daughter's head. Today St. Dymphna is the patron saint of people with mental illness and emotional and nervous disorders, and of victims of incest.

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St. Bartholomew: Flayed

St. Bartholomew

St. Bartholomew

Bartholomew (probably Nathanael bar Tolmai) is usually identified as one of the Twelve Apostles chosen by Jesus Christ. Little is known of him historically, and his death date is not known, but it is traditionally said that he died in Albanopolis, Armenia. There is evidence that he was a missionary to what are now Iran and Turkey as well as Armenia, Ethiopia, and Mesopotamia, and that the Armenian king Astyages called for his death after Bartholomew converted the king's brother. The manner of that death is a matter of dispute: Beheaded? Crucified upside-down? The method, however, with which Bartholomew is usually identified is singularly grotesque: flaying. That is, his skin was fully removed from his body, in strips, while he was still alive...and then he was beheaded for good measure. He is often depicted in art peeled, or half-peeled, with his "birthday suit" wrapped around him. St. Bartholomew is the patron saint of many causes and occupations, including tanners.

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Andrea da Firenze: St. Thomas Aquinas Enthroned Between the Doctors of the Old and New Testaments, with Personifications of the Virtues, Sciences, and Liberal Arts

Andrea da Firenze: St. Thomas Aquinas Enthroned Between the Doctors of the Old and New Testaments, with Personifications of the Virtues, Sciences, and Liberal Arts St. Thomas Aquinas Enthroned Between the Doctors of the Old and New Testaments, with Personifications of the Virtues, Sciences, and Liberal Arts, fresco by Andrea da Firenze, c. 1365; in the Spanish Chapel of the church of Santa Maria Novella, Florence.

doctor of the church

Christianity

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Top Questions

How many doctors of the church are there?

Who are the doctors of the church in Roman Catholicism?

How does Eastern Orthodoxy view the doctors of the church?

doctor of the church, in Roman Catholicism, any of the 38 saints whose doctrinal writings have special authority. The writings and teachings of the various doctors of the church are of particular importance to Roman Catholic theology, and their works are considered to be both true and timeless. Although the title is not used in the same way in Eastern Orthodoxy, the Orthodox church esteems the 17 doctors of the church who died before the East-West Schism of 1045, and Saints John Chrysostom, Basil the Great, and Gregory of Nazianzus are especially honored as the Three Holy Hierarchs.

(Who are the four female doctors of the church?)

In early Christianity the Western church recognized four doctors of the church—Ambrose, Augustine, Gregory the Great, and Jerome—and later adopted the Three Holy Hierarchs of the Eastern church and also Athanasius the Great.

Holy week. Easter. Valladolid. Procession of Nazarenos carry a cross during the Semana Santa (Holy week before Easter) in Valladolid, Spain. Good Friday

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Since the 16th century dozens more saints have been given the term doctor by formal proclamation of the Roman Catholic Church, among them Thomas Aquinas (1567), Bonaventure (1588), Anselm (1720), Leo I (1754), Bernard (1830), Francis of Sales (1877), the Venerable Bede (1899), Albertus Magnus (1931), Anthony of Padua (1946), and John Henry Newman (2025).

How to become a Saint

Catholic Online Saints & Angels

God calls all people to be saints. In one sense, all people in communion with the Church are saints (CCC 946-948). Anyone, even a non-Catholic, can be a saint if they possess sanctifying grace through the gift of the indwelling of the Holy Spirit. A saint is any person who resides in heaven with God.

But what about the canon of the Saints? That is, those individuals whom the Church recognizes are worthy of veneration and imitation?

The Church canonizes those who have lived a life of exceptional holiness and virtue. The Church also canonizes the martyred. Martyrdom means to give one's life as a witness to the faith.

Canonization is the process of formal investigation and recognition of saints. Canonized individuals become known as "saints."

To be clear, canonization does not make a person a saint. Only God can make a person a saint. Canonization is a recognition of sainthood. It is a decree made by the Church once investigators gather the evidence to prove a person is in heaven with God.

The first step in canonization is a waiting period. The Church requires five years must pass from the candidate's death. When a person passes away, their critics are often silent, out of respect. The emotional experience of death can influence attitudes. The waiting period allows feelings to subside, so reason may govern the process. It is easier to understand a person's life in hindsight than in the days after their passing. In some exceptional cases, the pope may waive this waiting period.

The first step involves a petitioner seeking a postulator in the candidate's diocese. A petitioner is a person who brings a matter of canon law before the Church. A postulator is a person who oversees and guides the initial process of canonization. The postulator will ask the diocesan bishop him to open the cause for canonization. Alternatively, a bishop may open a cause himself. Once the cause is open, the candidate for canonization is referred to as a "servant of God."

The bishop begins his work by consulting the faithful of the diocese. He will also bring the matter before his episcopal conference. If he finds no significant objections, he will present the servant of God to the Holy See. The Holy See may grant a "nihil obstat," meaning it does not object to the cause for canonization.

After the Holy See grants its permission to proceed, the bishop must form a tribunal. The tribunal begins by gathering evidence of how the servant of God lived. They may call witnesses as they study the person's life. Their purpose is to find evidence the person lived a life of holiness and heroic virtue. The tribunal will look for evidence of the cardinal virtues of prudence, justice, temperance, and fortitude, specific to their state in life. The bishop will submit his findings to the Congregation for the Causes of Saints.

The Congregation for the Causes of Saints is part of the Vatican curia. The Congregation works out of Vatican City, in Rome. The Congregation will appoint a person called a relator to replace the postulator. From this point on, the relator will take over the case.

The relator begins by gathering all the evidence in the case. Their goal is to prove the servant of God exercised heroic virtue or suffered martyrdom. The relator then submits a report called a "Posito."

Next, the team of nine theologians study the Posito. They each vote whether the candidate lived a heroic life or suffered martyrdom. The cause proceeds to the next step if the majority agrees it should.

The cause is then submitted to the nine bishops and cardinals who make up the Congregation. They also vote, and if the cause passes then the prefect of the Congregation will submit a report to the pope.

The pope will review everything submitted by the prefect. If he agrees, then he will give his permission to the Congregation to draft a special decree. The decree will declare before the Church that a person is either venerable or blessed.

All servants of God become venerable unless they suffer martyrdom. Martyrs are a special case, since they have died for the faith. The Congregation decrees them blessed instead because martyrs go to heaven without delay.

Venerable means the pope recognizes a person's heroic virtue, but they are not yet blessed. We should follow the example of venerable persons. Blessed refers to a person who is beatified. Beatification is a recognition that a person is in heaven, and may intercede for the living on Earth.

The Church needs evidence to know if a venerable person is in heaven. Miracles provide the evidence the Church needs.

Miracles occur all the time, and often they occur because a person has asked for intercession. There are many kinds of miracles which may occur. The Church may investigate when a miracle is attributed to the intercession of a venerable or blessed.

The investigation is rigorous. A Church commission will perform a rigorous investigation. The Church gathers evidence, and will call witnesses and experts. In most cases the commission finds a natural, scientific explanation. But sometimes the commission finds a supernatural event, which none can explain. Such events are supernatural miracles. While such miracles happen all the time, they are not always investigated.

If intercession is evident in the miracle, the Church may issue a decree. If the person is venerable, the pope will now declare the person is blessed. This means there is evidence the venerable is in heaven and may intercede before God on the behalf of the faithful on Earth.

For the blessed, one miracle is enough to decree their sainthood. The Church requires a second miracle for the venerable, to be certain of their sainthood.

Once the Church attributes a miracle to a blessed person, canonization will follow. The pope will conclude the process by announcing the blessed person is now part of the canon of saints.

Saints

The theological basis for the veneration of saints and their role in Christian life:

Mark 12:26-27; John 15:1-8; 1 Corinthians 12:25-27; Romans 12:4-5 emphasize the interconnectedness of the Church, both living and deceased, as part of Christ's body.

Ephesians 6:18; Romans 15:30; Colossians 4:3; 2 Thessalonians 1:10-12; Joshua 5:14; Daniel 8:17; Tobit 12:16; 1 Corinthians 13:12; 1 John 3:2; Luke 20:34-38; 2 Maccabees 15:11-16; Revelation 8:3-4; Jeremiah 15:1 cover aspects of intercessory prayer, angelic and saintly mediation, and the eternal life of the saints in heaven.

Mark 12:26-27

Authorized (King James) Version

26 And as touching the dead, that they rise: have ye not read in the book of Moses, how in the bush God spake unto him, saying, I am the God of Abraham, and the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob? 27 He is not the God of the dead, but the God of the living: ye therefore do greatly err.

John 15:1-8

Authorized (King James) Version

15 I am the true vine, and my Father is the husbandman. 2 Every branch in me that beareth not fruit he taketh away: and every branch that beareth fruit, he purgeth it, that it may bring forth more fruit. 3 Now ye are clean through the word which I have spoken unto you. 4 Abide in me, and I in you. As the branch cannot bear fruit of itself, except it abide in the vine; no more can ye, except ye abide in me. 5 I am the vine, ye are the branches: He that abideth in me, and I in him, the same bringeth forth much fruit: for without me ye can do nothing. 6 If a man abide not in me, he is cast forth as a branch, and is withered; and men gather them, and cast them into the fire, and they are burned. 7 If ye abide in me, and my words abide in you, ye shall ask what ye will, and it shall be done unto you. 8 Herein is my Father glorified, that ye bear much fruit; so shall ye be my disciples.

1 Corinthians 12:25-27

Authorized (King James) Version

25 that there should be no schism in the body; but that the members should have the same care one for another. 26 And whether one member suffer, all the members suffer with it; or one member be honoured, all the members rejoice with it.

27 Now ye are the body of Christ, and members in particular.

Romans 12:4-5

Authorized (King James) Version

4 For as we have many members in one body, and all members have not the same office: 5 so we, being many, are one body in Christ, and every one members one of another.

Ephesians 6:18

Authorized (King James) Version

18 praying always with all prayer and supplication in the Spirit, and watching thereunto with all perseverance and supplication for all saints;

Romans 15:30

Authorized (King James) Version

30 Now I beseech you, brethren, for the Lord Jesus Christ's sake, and for the love of the Spirit, that ye strive together with me in your prayers to God for me;

Colossians 4:3

Authorized (King James) Version

3 withal praying also for us, that God would open unto us a door of utterance, to speak the mystery of Christ, for which I am also in bonds:

2 Thessalonians 1:10-12

Authorized (King James) Version

10 when he shall come to be glorified in his saints, and to be admired in all them that believe (because our testimony among you was believed) in that day. 11 Wherefore also we pray always for you, that our God would count you worthy of this calling, and fulfil all the good pleasure of his goodness, and the work of faith with power: 12 that the name of our Lord Jesus Christ may be glorified in you, and ye in him, according to the grace of our God and the Lord Jesus Christ.

Joshua 5:14

Authorized (King James) Version

14 And he said, Nay; but as captain of the host of the Lord am I now come. And Joshua fell on his face to the earth, and did worship, and said unto him, What saith my lord unto his servant?

Daniel 8:17

Authorized (King James) Version

17 So he came near where I stood: and when he came, I was afraid, and fell upon my face: but he said unto me, Understand, O son of man: for at the time of the end shall be the vision.

Tobit 12:16

Douay-Rheims 1899 American Edition

16 And when they had heard these things, they were troubled, and being seized with fear they fell upon the ground on their face.

1 Corinthians 13:12

Authorized (King James) Version

12 For now we see through a glass, darkly; but then face to face: now I know in part; but then shall I know even as also I am known.

1 John 3:2

Authorized (King James) Version

2 Beloved, now are we the sons of God, and it doth not yet appear what we shall be: but we know that, when he shall appear, we shall be like him; for we shall see him as he is.

Luke 20:34-38

Authorized (King James) Version

34 And Jesus answering said unto them, The children of this world marry, and are given in marriage: 35 but they which shall be accounted worthy to obtain that world, and the resurrection from the dead, neither marry, nor are given in marriage: 36 neither can they die any more: for they are equal unto the angels; and are the children of God, being the children of the resurrection. 37 Now that the dead are raised, even Moses shewed at the bush, when

he calleth the Lord the God of Abraham, and the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob. 38 For he is not a God of the dead, but of the living: for all live unto him.

2 Maccabees 15:11-16

Douay-Rheims 1899 American Edition

11 So he armed every one of them, not with defence of shield and spear, but with very good speeches and exhortations, and told them a dream worthy to be believed, whereby he rejoiced them all.

12 Now the vision was in this manner: Onias who had been high priest, a good and virtuous man, modest in his looks, gentle in his manners, and graceful in his speech, and who from a child was exercised in virtues, holding up his hands, prayed for all the people of the Jews:

13 After this there appeared also another man, admirable for age, and glory, and environed with great beauty and majesty:

14 Then Onias answering, said: This is a lover of his brethren, and of the people of Israel: this is he that prayeth much for the people, and for all the holy city, Jeremias the prophet of God.

15 Whereupon Jeremias stretched forth his right hand, and gave to Judas a sword of gold, saying:

16 Take this holy sword a gift from God, wherewith thou shalt overthrow the adversaries of my people Israel.

Revelation 8:3-4

Authorized (King James) Version

3 And another angel came and stood at the altar, having a golden censer; and there was given unto him much incense, that he should offer it with the prayers of all saints upon the golden altar which was before the throne. 4 And the smoke of the incense, which came with the prayers of the saints, ascended up before God out of the angel's hand.

Jeremiah 15:1

Authorized (King James) Version

15 Then said the Lord unto me, Though Moses and Samuel stood before me, yet my mind could not be toward this people: cast them out of my sight, and let them go forth.

Saints

Mk 12:26-27 ... "not God of the dead, but of the living."

Jn 15:1-8 ... vine and its branches.

1 Cor 12:25-27; Rom 12:4-5 ... body of Christ.

Eph 6:18; Rom 15:30; Col 4:3; 1 Thess 1:11 ... intercessory prayer.

Jos 5:14; Dan 8:17; Tob 12:16 ... veneration of angels united with God (Mt 18:10).

1 Cor 13:12; 1 John 3:2 ... saints also united with God.

Lk 20:34-38 ... those who died are like angels.

2 Mac 15:11-16 ... deceased Onias and Jeremiah interceded for Jews.
Rev 8:3-4; Jer 15:1 ... saints' intercession.

Apologetics

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Catholic Apologetics Guide 101

The word "ALL" from the Bible

From the Joshua Caswell's website Mary Defended

Rom 3:23: "for all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God..."

The problem with this is that the word 'ALL' here is the Greek word, 'PAS', which can have different meanings to the absolute that we immediately think of – as shown in other verses of Holy Scripture.

John 12:19, "All the world has gone after him!" Did everyone in the entire world really go after Christ?

Mt 3:5-6, "Then went out to Him Jerusalem, and ALL Judea, and ALL the region about the Jordan; and they were baptized by him in the Jordan, confessing their sins."

Were all of the people of Judea, and the region about the Jordan baptized?

Luke 2:1 "And an order went out from caesar Augustus that ALL the world should be counted."

Was everyone in the whole world counted?

Rom 11:26, "ALL Israel shall be saved." Will everyone in Israel truly be saved?

Rom 15:14, "...you yourselves are full of love, filled with ALL knowledge..." The only person filled with 'ALL' knowledge is God Himself.

The Greek word 'PAS' in many verses in Scripture simply means a 'great number', 'most of', or 'a lot'. So its appearance in the quoted passage can in no way be used as an objection to the sinlessness of the Virgin Mary.

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The Communion of Saints

There Are Saints and There Are Saints

The teaching of the Catholic Church is that our departed brothers and sisters in Christ reign in heaven with God, who is a God of the living (cf. Matthew 22:32), and therefore enjoy an especially close relationship with him. This does not deny that Christians still combating their way through the trials of this world are saints (from the Latin for holy, sanctus), because we are children of God even now. But in the new life, we will be like God:

Beloved, we are God's children now; it does not yet appear what we shall be, but we know that when he appears we shall be like him, for we shall see him as he is. (1 John 3)

In heaven, we will reach the fullness of the image of God.

For now we see in a mirror dimly, but then face to face. (1 Cor 13)

The saints are to God like stained glass is to sunlight. Light from the sun is white, but when passed through a prism or colored glass, its constitution becomes evident: the many colors that combine to form its radiance dance varied hues and textures to reveal the hidden perfections of the original light beam. So it is with the saints. Their lives and their faith show the perfections of God's holiness shining through our human weakness. By contemplating and honoring their goodness, we come better to know and revere the overawing holiness of God.

Example in the Saints

And we desire each one of you to show the same earnestness in realizing the full assurance of hope until the end, so that you may not be sluggish, but imitators of those who through faith and patience inherit the promises. (Hebrews 6:11-12)

Be imitators of me, as I am of Christ. (1 Cor 11:1, cf. 1 Cor 4:16)

Reverence for the Saints

Only God should be worshipped. Yet, we should also honor those to whom honor is due. It is not that God alone should be honored; instead, it is far more honorable to God to praise him as excelling the greatness of something great, than to praise him as better than nothingness. When you praise a child in front of its parents, they do not take offense. Rather they take your praise of their child as a complement. Similarly, every time we praise excellence in a creature, we implicitly praise the Creator who has brought forth such goodness.

The Church calls the worship of God latria and distinguishes it from dulia, the reverence due the saints.

Calling to mind the virtues of the saints helps us to appreciate better God's all-encompassing goodness. It is easy to fail to appreciate the infinity of the sky, but we more easily appreciate it when we compare our smallness to a towering mountain or to a cloud sailing low overhead and then realize that the sky looms farther above than we can imagine.

Acts 19:12	relics of saints
Hebrews 12:1	cloud of witnesses
Images of the Saints	

Rest assured, the only image that Catholics worship is Jesus Christ. He is “the image of the invisible God” (Col 1:15), for “in him the whole fullness of deity dwells bodily” (Col 2:9).

The worship of images of the saints is condemned by the Catholic Church. The idea dating back to beginnings of Christianity is that there is more to the Church than we see here on earth: all believers, living and dead, form one family. Having the images of holy men and women in churches is like carrying the photograph of a loved one; such an image helps to call to mind the person and one’s love for them.

The veneration of images is not a violation of the First Commandment. The Catechism of the Catholic Church points out:

2129 The divine injunction included the prohibition of every representation of God by the hand of man. Deuteronomy explains: “Since you saw no form on the day that the Lord spoke to you at Horeb out of the midst of the fire, beware lest you act corruptly by making a graven image for yourselves, in the form of any figure....”[66] It is the absolutely transcendent God who revealed himself to Israel. “He is the all,” but at the same time “he is greater than all his works.”[67] He is “the author of beauty.”[68]

2130 Nevertheless, already in the Old Testament, God ordained or permitted the making of images that pointed symbolically toward salvation by the incarnate Word: so it was with the bronze serpent, the ark of the covenant, and the cherubim.[69]

2131 Basing itself on the mystery of the incarnate Word, the seventh ecumenical council at Nicaea (787) [see below] justified against the iconoclasts the veneration of icons – of Christ, but also of the Mother of God, the angels, and all the saints. By becoming incarnate, the Son of God introduced a new “economy” of images.

2132 The Christian veneration of images is not contrary to the first commandment which proscribes idols. Indeed, “the honor rendered to an image passes to its prototype,” and “whoever venerates an image venerates the person portrayed in it.”[70] The honor paid to sacred images is a “respectful veneration,” not the adoration due to God alone: Religious worship is not directed to images in themselves, considered as mere things, but under their distinctive aspect as images leading us on to God incarnate. The movement toward the image does not terminate in it as image, but tends toward that whose image it is.[71]

The practice of keeping in Churches the images of saints dates back to the earliest days of Christianity. The practice was so widespread that it only became an issue in the eighth century, when a group known as iconoclasts rose to declare veneration of images idolatrous. The seventh ecumenical council (council of all bishops) of the Church held in Nicea in 787 A.D. was organized to refute the opponents of icons:

To summarize, we declare that we defend free from any innovations all the written and unwritten ecclesiastical traditions that have been entrusted to us. One of these is the production of representational art; this is quite in harmony with the history of the spread of the gospel, as it provides confirmation that the becoming man of

the Word of God was real and not just imaginary, and as it brings us a similar benefit. For, things that mutually illustrate one another undoubtedly possess one another's message.

Given this state of affairs and stepping out as though on the royal highway, following as we are the God-spoken teaching of our holy fathers and the tradition of the catholic church—for we recognize that this tradition comes from the holy Spirit who dwells in her— we decree with full precision and care that, like the figure of the honoured and life-giving cross, the revered and holy images, whether painted or made of mosaic or of other suitable material, are to be exposed in the holy churches of God, on sacred instruments and vestments, on walls and panels, in houses and by public ways; these are the images of our Lord, God and saviour, Jesus Christ, and of our Lady without blemish, the holy God-bearer, and of the revered angels and of any of the saintly holy men. The more frequently they are seen in representational art, the more are those who see them drawn to remember and long for those who serve as models, and to pay these images the tribute of salutation and respectful veneration. Certainly this is not the full adoration in accordance with our faith, which is properly paid only to the divine nature, but it resembles that given to the figure of the honored and life-giving cross, and also to the holy books of the gospels and to other sacred cult objects. Further, people are drawn to honor these images with the offering of incense and lights, as was piously established by ancient custom. Indeed the honor paid to an image traverses it, reaching the model; and he who venerates the image, venerates the person represented in that image. (pp. 135-7)

The council condemned the opponents of images, specifically

“...anyone [who] does not confess that Christ our God can be represented in his humanity...”

“...anyone [who] does not accept representation in art of evangelical scenes...”

“...anyone [who] does not salute such representations as standing for the Lord and his saints...”

“...anyone [who] rejects any written or unwritten tradition of the church...”

Intercessors

Often, perhaps when life is troubling us, we'll ask a relative or close friend to pray for us. It is very good that we do ask people to pray for us and our needs and also to pray for them. Praying to the saints is like asking your friend to pray for you. You still pray to Jesus, but your friend is praying with you. Not only does prayer help benefit the receiver, but also the person who prays: it draws us all into closer union with Christ and with each other.

The saints are our fellow Christians who have died in God's favor, and now stand before God face to face, in the closest union with him. God is well pleased with them, and so, like a doting grandparent, he is especially willing to grant their petitions.

When we here on earth have recourse to the saints by praying to them, we are merely asking them to ask God for us. The use of the word 'pray' might put off some people here, but when we pray to the saints, we are not praying to them as to God. This use of 'pray' is similar to the older use of the word as in 'praying to the court' to mean petitioning the court.

But the souls of the righteous are in the hand of God, and no torment will ever touch them. In the eyes of the foolish they seemed to have died, and their departure was thought to be an affliction, and their going from us to be their destruction; but they are at peace. For though in the sight of men they were punished, their hope is full of immortality. Having been disciplined a little, they will receive great good, because God tested them and found them worthy of himself; like gold in the furnace he tried them, and like a sacrificial burnt offering he accepted them. In

the time of their visitation they will shine forth, and will run like sparks through the stubble. They will govern nations and rule over peoples, and the Lord will reign over them for ever. Those who trust in him will understand truth, and the faithful will abide with him in love, because grace and mercy are upon his elect, and he watches over his holy ones.

Wisdom 3:1-9 (cf. Daniel 12:1-3)

Sign of Encouragement

Recalling the victory of the saints is a great encouragement for us Christians still combating our way through the trials of this world. Thomas Howard recalls an evangelical hymn 'Art thou weary, art thou languid' from his youth:

After speaking for six exquisite verses about the difficulties of following Jesus, the hymn concludes, "Finding following keeping struggling/Is he sure to bless?/Angels, prophets, martyrs, virgins/Answer, Yes." I was overwhelmed by this picture. What solace! What encouragement! I was in an ancient lineage, and all of these forerunners knew everything I had experienced, and all of them could testify, "Keep going! It is worth it! Praise God!"

SAINTS

"We give thanks to God and the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, praying always for you. Hearing your faith in Christ Jesus and the love which you have towards all the Saints".

Colossians 1:3

The Scriptures | The Church Fathers Speak

The doctrine of the Catholic Church with respect to the honor which is due to the saints, and especially to the blessed Virgin, is founded on the most obvious principles of reason ; and expressly sanctioned by numerous and explicit warrants of Scripture.

We are inclined, by the impulse of nature, to be pleased with objects that are beautiful, and the best feelings of the human heart prompt us to do homage to goodness and virtue. Those feelings are in perfect accordance with the principles of right reason, for it cannot be wrong to admire excellence nor unreasonable to esteem what is worthy of veneration.

God commands us to "render to all men their dues, tribute to whom tribute is due, custom to whom custom, fear to whom fear, and honor to whom honor" (Rom. 13; 7), and thus expressly sanctions our doing homage to the exalted dignity and transcendent splendor of His servants in heaven, who, "having overcome, are clothed in white, and walk with

Him because they are worthy." (Rev. 3. 4.) Jesus Christ declares that to those " that shall overcome, He will give to sit with Him on His throne" (Rev. 3: 21), "and they shall be like to the angels of God in heaven " (Matt. xxii. 30), "and shine like the sun in the kingdom of their Father" (Matt. xiii. 43); that "they shall see God face to face" (1 Cor. xiii. 12); "and beholding the glory of the Lord with open face, they are transformed into the same image, from glory to glory, by the spirit of the Lord" (2 Cor. 3. 18), "and they shall reign for ever and ever." (Rev. 21.-22. 5.)

Such is the dignity which the Lord God confers upon His servants. He exalts them to a fellowship with Himself, and makes them partakers of His throne and glory. It is an imperative duty, therefore, to honor the saints, and in doing so we follow the example of God Himself.

But while the dignity of the saints claims our respectful homage, their ardent charity demands the warmest affection of our hearts. Seeing God face to face, they cannot cease to love Him, and loving Him, they must also love all the members of His mystical body here on earth, and earnestly desire their eternal happiness ; for " there is joy before the angels of God upon one sinner doing penance." (Luke xv. 10.) It is therefore a portion of the happiness as well as of the duty of the saints to pray to God for their brethren on earth. " And the four living creatures, and the four and twenty ancients fell down before the Lamb, having

every one of them harps and golden vials full of odors which are the prayers of the saints" (Rev. v. 8); "and another angel came and stood before the altar, having a golden censer, and there was given to him much incense, that he should offer the prayer of all the saints upon the golden altar, which is before the throne of God. And the smoke of the incense of the prayers of the saints ascended up before God, from the hand of the angel." (Rev. viii. 3.) And the angel Raphael speaks as follows to holy Tobias :

" when thou didst pray with tears, and didst bury the dead, and didst leave thy dinner, and hide the dead by day in thy house, and bury them by night, I offered thy prayers to the Lord " (Tob. xii. 12); and in Zach. i. 12 we read that "the angel of the Lord answered and said, O Lord of hosts, how long wilt thou not have mercy on Jerusalem ; and on the cities of Juda with which thou hast been angry ? This is now the seventh year : and the Lord answered the angel, that spoke in me, good words, comfortable words."

Here, then, is evidence that the angels and saints offer up their prayers to the throne of grace on behalf of their brethren on earth and that God responds to them "good words, comfortable words." It is absurd, therefore, to deny that it is lawful to ask for the prayers of the blessed

in heaven. Such prayers are evidently agreeable to God, and must be profitable to man. For as "the Lord accepted the face of Job" (42. 8), who was still in this state of probation, how much more the face of those who "have proved themselves worthy ;" "who are made to their God a kingdom and priests" (Rev. v. 10); "who shall judge nations and rule over people" (Wisd. 3. 8), "and shall reign upon the earth." (Rev. v. 10.)

In conformity with the evidence of the foregoing, and numerous other express warrants of Holy Writ, the Catholic Church teaches that " The saints who reign with Christ offer up their prayers to God for men, and that it is useful and good to invoke them, and to have recourse to their prayers, help and assistance, in order to obtain blessings from God, through His Son, Jesus Christ our Lord, who alone is our Redeemer and Saviour." (Cone. Trid., Sess. 25.) In the catechism of the Council of Trent, the infinite difference between the worship which is due to God, and the honor which, on His account, may be given to the saints, is so

strongly marked and so fully and clearly explained as to obviate all the cavils raised against Catholics on that subject. A Catholic child, acquainted with the first outlines of the Christian doctrine, will commit no mistake on that point ; and the most rude peasant in the most remote part of Ireland, is quite aware that it would be idolatry to give

to the saints the honor which he owes to God, from whom alone he hopes for mercy, while he looks for nothing from the saints but the assistance of their prayers ; and hence it is that he always concludes his supplication to the saints with the words, " through our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ."

It is often objected; 'Isn't Jesus the Son of God, the only Mediator between God and man?

Jesus is truly the only Mediator between God and man. The Catholic Church recognizes and venerates Saints because they led exceptional lives in union with God and in return for their good works and perfect example, God blessed them with miracles through their prayers and intercessions.

Catholics do not worship Saints, they venerate, honour and imitate their virtues; the virtues which led them into profound holiness, an exceptional life lived only for the glory of God. Catholics pray to God and ask the saints to pray for us, Catholics do not pray "to" the saints, we pray "with" the saints as we unit ourselves with them, because Catholics believe in the "Communion of Saints" (Romans 12:4). That is those saints in heaven and those on earth are united by the common head (Jesus Christ). Further St. James enjoins the Christians to "pray for one another that you may be saved. For the continual prayer of a just man availeth much"(James 5:16) .

The Holy Bible has revealed that God respects the intercession of those who led such lives, who resigned themselves completely to His Holy Will, who lived and laboured for His glory.

The perfect example of an intercessor would be of Mary, the Mother of Jesus. She, at the wedding of Cana, interceded when the wine ran out, and said to the servants, even though it was not yet time for Jesus to begin His public ministry: "Do whatever He tells you." St. John 2:5

Jesus respects and honours the intercession of His Mother, the Mother who gave birth to Him, nourished Him, loved Him, and finally raised Him and prepared Him for His Ministry. Our Lady played and instrumental part in the life of Jesus, from the time of His Birth until His Death. Mary stood by Her Crucified Son at the foot of the Cross and held Him one last time before She placed Him in the Tomb.

As far as the remission of sins and redemption of mankind are concerned, Jesus is the sole Mediator who sacrificed Himself for the forgiveness of sins.

Nowhere does it state in the Bible, that those who have resigned themselves completely to God's Will, cannot intercede on behalf of those who call upon their intercession (to pray for their intentions). On the contrary, in the Old Testament, many of the great prophets have interceded, and through their intercessions, prayers and sacrifices, God had granted their requests.

In Genesis 18:23-26, we have Abraham interceding to God for the inhabitants of Sodom and Gomorrah:

"Will you sweep away the innocent with the guilty? Suppose there were fifty innocent people in the city; would you wipe out the place, rather than spare it for the sake of the fifty innocent people within it? Far be it from you to do such a thing, to make the innocent die with the guilty, so that the innocent and the guilty would be treated alike? Should not the Judge of all the world with justice?" The Lord replied: "If I find fifty innocent people in the city of Sodom, I will spare the whole place for their sake" Genesis 18:23-26

God through His infinite Mercy relented to Abraham's intercession, by saying if there were found fifty just, He would spare the whole city.

"...I Am the God of your father Abraham, You have no need to fear, since I Am with you, I will bless you and multiply your descendants For the sake of My servant Abraham." Genesis 26:23

On account of God's servant Abraham, God blessed Isaac and multiplied his descendants. These verses show us the place for the righteous in God's Heart.

Moses himself Called out to God saying Exodus 32:11 "Remember Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, your servants, to whom by yourself you swore and mad this promise". From it we note that Moses pleads with God on the basis of the Promise he made to his earthly friends. Moses (indirectly) used their assistance to help him just as we do when we ask the saints to pray for us.

Intercession of the dead saints is further confirmed by the scriptures when we read that God himself says to Solom 1 Kings 11 "for your Fathers sake, However, I will not do this (take away his kingdom)during your life time but will tear it out of your Son's hands. . . . for the sake of my servant David and for the sake of Jerusalem which I have chosen, I will leave your son one tribe".

"Then, as before, I lay prostrate before the Lord for forty days and forty nights without eating and drinking, because of all the sin you had committed in the sight of the Lord...Yet once again the Lord listened to me. With Aaron too, the Lord was deeply angry, and would have killed him had I not prayed for him also at that time. Deutronomy 9:18-20

If Moses had not interceded before God, who was very angry with the evil they had done, He would have surely destroyed them.

"...Grant our petition; pray for us to the Lord, your God, for all this remnant...Let the Lord your God, show us what way we should take and what we should do." "Very well," The prophet Jeremiah answered them: "I will pray to the Lord, your God, as you desire..." Jeremiah 42:2-4

It is very clear that the army leaders Johanan, the sons of Kareah, Azariah, the son of Hoshai and their people are petitioning Jeremiah to pray for them, to intercede to His God.

The Lord Jesus commands that we pray for one another, especially those who have strayed from the Truth:

"But to you here I say, love your enemies, do good to those who hate you, bless those who curse you, pray for those who mistreat you." St. Luke 6:27-28

One of Jesus disciples, Stephen the first martyr, whilst being stoned to death interceded in prayer on behalf of those stoning him:

"...Lord, do not hold this sin against them;" and when he said this, he fell asleep." The Acts 7:60

In the following verse St. James reveals the power of prayer to those who are righteous (Saints):

"...The fervent prayer of a righteous person is very powerful. Elijah was a human being like us; yet when he prayed earnestly that it might not rain upon the land. Then he prayed again, and the sky gave rain and the earth produced its fruit." St. James 5:16-18

"Call Now, if there be any that will answer thee: and to which of the saints wilt thou turn?" (Job 5:1)

St. Elijah was rewarded with many gifts through his love for God, as he offered his life to serve and honour Him. In the following verses we have the righteous asking people to pray to God for one another:

"I desire therefore, first of all, that supplications, prayers, intercessions, and thanksgivings be made for all men...that we may lead a quiet and a peaceful life in all piety and chastity." 1 St. Timothy 2:1-2

"With all prayer and supplication, pray at every opportunity in the Spirit. To that end, be watchful with all perseverance and supplication for all the Saints: And for me, that speech may be given me, that I may open my mouth with confidence..." Ephesians 6:18-19 In the following, the righteous are praying for one another and at the same time are asking for each others prayer:

"To Timothy my dearly beloved son...I give thanks to God, whom I serve from my forefathers with a pure conscience, that without ceasing, I have a remembrance of Thee in my prayers, night and day." 2 St. Timothy 1:2-3 Simon the magician asks Peter and John to intercede on his behalf:

We note also that when Simon the Magician said to Peter and John (Acts 8:24) "Pray to the Lord for me" "yourselves so that none of the things you have spoken about may happen" he was not rebuked for such a statement for indeed it was a righteous one.

Let us not lose sight that Our God is the God of the Living and not of the dead. Physical death does not exclude a person from God's presence, but re-unites them in Heaven. Therefore there should be not any difference between the intercession of the living righteous people and those of dead saints. The Inspired Word of God offers examples of intercessions of dead persons (Holy persons), in order to obtain graces and favours for the living who were spared because of the prayers of the Saints who have already departed from this world. The following verses show God's regard for His faithful Saints and their prayers:

"But Moses implored the Lord, His God, saying: 'Why O' Lord, should your wrath blaze up against your own people, whom you brought out of the land of Egypt with such great power and with a strong hand?...Let your blazing Wrath die down: relent in punishing your people, remember Your servants Abraham, Isaac, and Israel..." Exodus 32:11-14

Moses is interceding on behalf of his living nation, asking the Lords Mercy For the sake of their dead ancestors who were righteous before God (see also Jer 15:1).

"I will shield and save this city for my own sake, and for the sake of My servant David." Isaias 37:35

"For the sake of David your servant, reject not the plea of Your Anointed." Psalm 132:10

Samuel intercedes before the Lord for the People: 1 Samuel 7:5

The People of God ask for the intercession of the holy ones: Jeremiah 42:2

The Inspired Word of God likewise states that those living, should pray for the dead:

"It is therefore a holy and wholesome thought to pray for the dead, that they may be loosed from sins." 2 Machabees 12:46.

2Machabees 15:11-16 attests the faith of the Jewish people in the intercession of the saints as Judas the Maccabean sees in a "credible" vision how two deceased just men, the Highpriest Onias and the prophet Jeremias, intercede with God for the Jewish people and for the Holy City.

The above verse reveals there is life after death and through the prayers of the living, we are able to assist those who are dead to be freed from sins. Though they are not with us physically, we are called to pray for them.

The New Testament mentions the intercession of Saints who are no longer physically present:

"And another Angel came, and stood before the altar, having a golden censer; and there was given to him much incense, that he should offer, of the prayers of all the Saints upon the golden altar...And the smoke of the incense of the prayers of the Saints ascended up before God." Revelations 8:3-4

The above quote reveals the presence of Saints in Heaven and their prayers ascending to God (interceding).

"What you have come to is Mount Zion and the city of the Living God, the Heavenly Jerusalem...You have been placed with the spirits of the Just who had been made perfect..." Hebrews 12:23-24

The faithful (the living), are in communion with the Heavenly Jerusalem and with the dead Saints (Spirits of the Just). In fact, they are spiritually one with the spirits of the righteous people made perfect. These righteous persons, the Just, are in fact the Saints who have been made perfect by entering the Kingdom of God, Heaven.

The Saints, whether alive or dead, intercede for us by virtue of the One Body in Christ, of whose members we all are, whether we are on earth or in Heaven. This Doctrine, based on the Scripture, is called the 'Communion of Saints.'

Whether we stay in this physical body of ours - or we leave it, we are with the Lord and He is with us. So, there is nothing that may stop our prayers ascending to the Living God, for our brothers and sisters, friends and foes who are still on earth. We too, even after we pass away, are always alive and in the Presence of the Almighty Living God.

Through Baptism, we become members of One Body, whose Head is Christ, and members of each other. Nothing, not even physical death, can separate us from Christ and His love, which includes the love of all the members of Christ's Body. So, even after death (which does not change anything in the spiritual Body of Christ), Saints continue to pray for all who call upon them, the only difference is, they are in Heaven.

St Peter did not condemn the practice of honoring the saints , but what he was against is people falling at his feet to adore him as St. Peter acknowledged that he indeed was a sinner and that Christ had chosen him for his ministry even though he (like ourselves) was not worthy. If you look at the actions of Cornillus he fell down and "adored" peter, this is something the Church condemns also . The ground for the veneration of the angels is their supernatural dignity, which is rooted in their immediate union with God (Matt 18:10). Since the saints also are immediately joined to God (1 Cor 13:12, 1John 3:2), it follows that they too are worthy of veneration.

Catholics honor the saints and Mary but we adore only God. In the life of st. Peter many had placed themselves before him (Acts 5:15) so that they may be healed by his shadow, Peter did not turn them away because they came to honor and Trust in Christ through him but Cornillus put his adoration in the "Man" Peter, were as the others put their hope in Christ through the intercession of St. Peter.

The Scriptures also show us that even relics of saints (Ex 13:19, 4 Kings 13:21, 4 Kings 2:13, Acts 19:12) were used to cure people, not that the relics were anything of themselves but rather they had touched one that was highly favored by God.

To honour and venerate Saints, to call upon their assistance is a great sign of God's Mercy, because of their status in God's eyes. The intercession of the Saints is confirmed to God's desire as their will is to do God's Will and that God may be glorified through their requests on behalf of the faithful (the living). Even the Psalmist David in his prayer and praise of the Angels of God says (Psalm 103), "WE PRAY, "Bless the Lord, O you his angels, you mighty ones who do his word, hearkening to the voice of his word! Bless the Lord, all his hosts, his ministers that do his will!" (Ps. 103:20-21). And in Psalm 148 WE PRAY, "Praise the Lord! Praise the Lord from the heavens, praise him in the heights! Praise him, all his angels, praise him, all his host!" (Ps. 148:1-2) .

The saints continue to intercede for us as they are not dead but indeed living as " God is not the God of the Dead but of the living" (Matt 22:32).) The saints in heaven are really more alive than we are now. In the arms of God, they are even more solicitous of us than when they were on earth. Just as Paul asked the other disciples to pray for him (Rom. 15:30, Col 4:3, 1 Thess. 5:25) as he prayed for them (2 Thess. 1:11), so now we can ask Paul and the other saints in heaven to intercede for us with God. we are not cut off from our fellow Christians at death, but are brought closer. We continue in one communion, the communion of saints.

It seems that some have drawn the false conclusion from 1Timothy 2:5 as if somebody asks you to pray for them, to intercede for them to God on their behalf, should one go around and say, "How dare you undermine the sole mediation of Jesus Christ, the only High Priest?" Of course not. Why? Because what does Paul say in the first four verses before 1st Timothy, 2:1, "First of all then, I urge the supplications, prayers, intercessions and thanksgivings be made for all men." By Jesus alone? Of course not. By us, "for kings and all who are in high positions in order that we might lead a quiet and peaceful life, Godly and respectful in every way. This is good and is acceptable by God our Savior who desires all men to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth. For there is one God and there is one mediator between God and man."

Because there's one mediator. Does that mean no other intercessors, no others to make supplication? No! But as St. Paul Shows us on the contrary, in fact it is precisely because there is one mediator and because our mediator is the most awesome mediator that we have now the capacity to intercede as priests in the Priest, as sons in the Son, as pastors and shepherds in the one Pastor and Shepherd. We draw our life from him. "No longer I, but Christ who lives in me. Apart from Christ, I can do nothing."

The verse in no way rules out intercession of the saints, but rather affirms (as the Church teaches) that Christ's mediation is unique in as the intercession of the saints is not a mediation of redemption but there's a second mediation so that the faithful may obtain spiritual and material favors and graces. On Christ's unique Mediation we read "He (Jesus) brings a new covenant as the Mediator only so that the people who were called to an eternal inheritance may actually receive what was promised"(Hebrews 9:15). The influence of the saints, before God, does not affect the universal redemption, where Christ alone saves (see John 14:6, Acts 4:6, Romans 5:11).

A further objection is made on the basis that St. John in the apocalypse is rebuked by the angel for falling before him. However the same book of Revelations shows us that both the angels and the saints place the prayers of the holy on earth before the throne of God (Rev 5:8, Rev 8:3), that is, they support them with their intercession as also might be expected from the permanency of charity (1Cor 13:8).

Further if we read that verse (Rev 22: 5) it shows us that even St. John knew that Christians did indeed honor the Angels and Saints as even Daniel had prostrated himself before the angel of the lord (Daniel 8:16 - 18, See also Josue 5:14). However the angel lifted up St. John telling him that now they were both "fellow servant". Although the real problem is that the word used here in sacred Scripture is "Adore" and so indeed we adore no one but God, however many Protestant bibles often generalize the word worship and so some scriptures read "worship" which is rather a problem in translation more than anything. The Catholic (Douay-Rheims) Bible reads "adore" not worship in general .